



save, the creature takes 9 (2d8) piercing damage, or half as much damage on a successful save.

A character searching the stairs and the dais notes the trap with a successful DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check, and can easily step around it. A character climbing the stairs without searching spots the trap only if his or her passive Perception is 18 or higher. A character climbing the stairs at speed has no chance to spot the trap.

UNFORTUNATE VISITOR

The body being feasted on by the zombies wears the armor and regalia of a cleric, but has been mutilated beyond recognition. (The characters can learn later that this is one of the Grave Robbers. The last one of the group to climb down into this area, he was killed when his climbing rope broke.)

Any character searching the north end of the room notes a pile of broken tile and stone on the ground next to thirty feet of rope with a frayed end. A hole in the ceiling above the pile connects to a rough tunnel leading aboveground, and has a short length of frayed rope visible where it's tied off around a rock spur.

TURNING THE KEY

The large brass key is magically fitted to the keyhole underneath the bas relief of Kelemvor's symbol, and cannot be removed. When any character turns the key, the scales in the bas relief magically right themselves, and the characters hear the faint sound of a stone door grinding open in the distance, back toward the entrance. (This is the means by which the characters gain entrance to area 9 and the levels below.)

Turning the key back in the other direction puts the scales out of balance once more and closes the door into area 9. Otherwise, after one hour, the key magically

turns back, the scales go out of balance once more, and the door to area 9 automatically closes.

(The Grave Robbers knew of the key's function before entering the chapel through the hole in the ceiling. They quickly turned the key, then fled through this area to avoid fighting the undead here.)

TREASURE

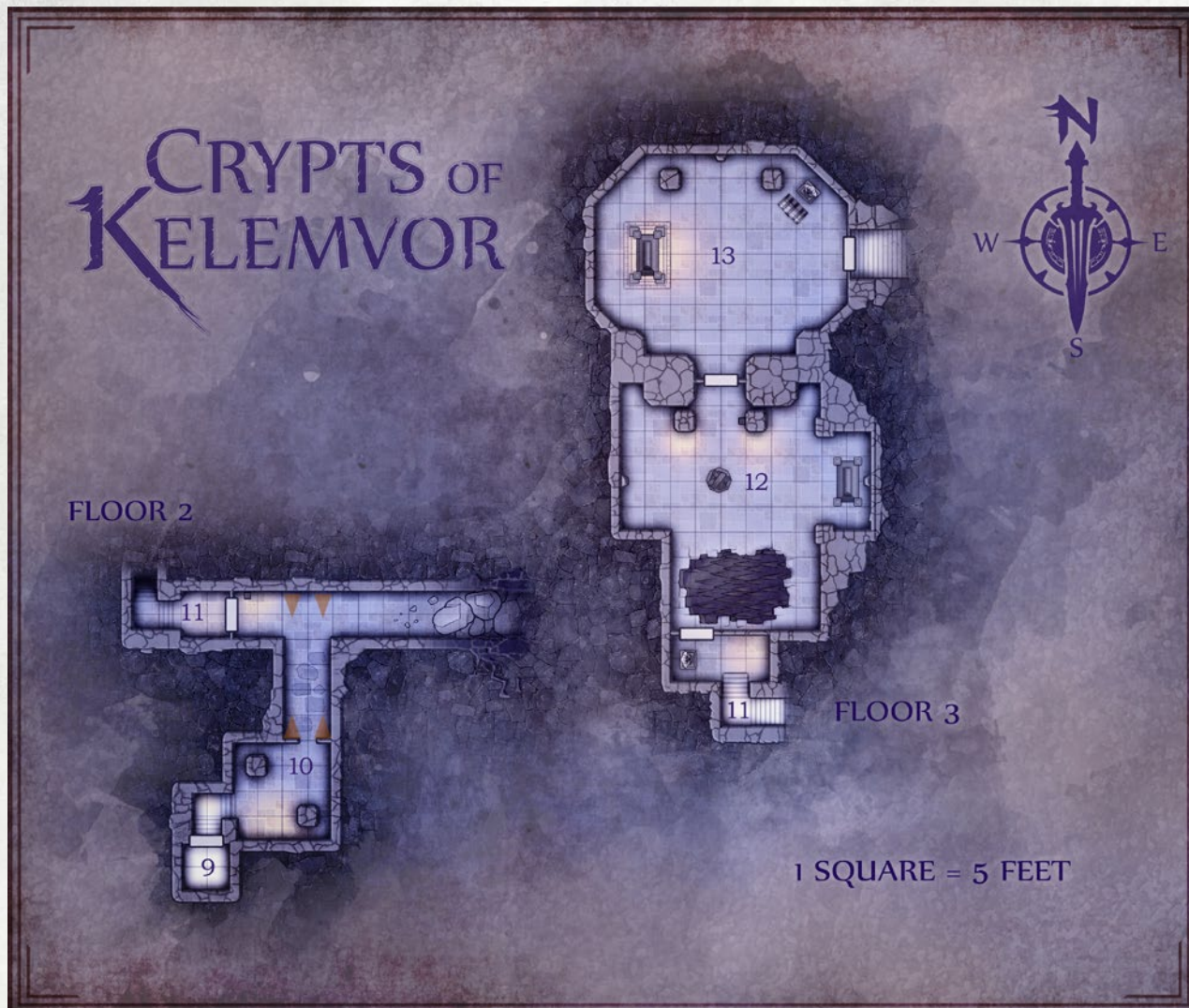
The dead cleric wears a breastplate in good condition, but it's in bad need of cleaning. If the body is rolled over, the characters find a pouch with a broken potion vial in it, but the body's weapons and pack are gone (quickly grabbed up by the Grave Robbers when they fled this area).

AREA 9: DARK STAIRS

When the adventurers return to the central intersection (area 2) after turning the key on the dais in area 8, they will see that the stone door to the north has opened as a result.

Beyond the door stands a small room with a lever next to another stone door, already open. Beyond that door, a set of steep stairs leads down into darkness.

A character making a successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check notes that the second door has been wedged with a spike to keep it open. The door from area 2 was likewise spiked, but the spike was shattered when the door magically closed. A successful DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check discovers a hidden latch that opens the door to area 2 from inside this area.



AREA 10: WARDED HALL

The initial chamber of this area holds only a pair of stone columns, but a dark hallway leads north toward a T-intersection and an east–west corridor.

A successful DC 11 Wisdom (Perception) check notes a number of broken crossbow bolts around the southwest column and the southern wall of the initial chamber. This might offer the players a hint of the trap beyond.

CROSSBOW TRAP

The north-leading hallway is set with a series of pressure plates in the floor, in the area between the triangles appearing on the map. The plates are made of iron concealed under years of dust and rubble, and can be spotted with a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check. Characters not spotting the trap will step on the pressure plates, causing four crossbow bolts to be fired through holes in the north wall. Any characters in the hallway or the eastern part of the initial chamber have

the trap's four attacks randomly divided among them: +4 to hit, 5 (1d10) piercing damage.

The bolts fly the length of the hallway and hit the southwest column and the south wall if they don't strike anyone. If the characters bypass the area and make it safely to the T-intersection, they can easily see the holes in the wall out of which the crossbow bolts fly.

MOVING ON

The eastern arm of the intersection leads to a collapsed section of hallway that can't be dug out. To the west is a portcullis and a lever, with stairs seen just beyond. The portcullis is already open. Any check made to search it reveals that it is wedged with a spike so that it cannot be closed.

AREA 11: FAINTLY LIT STAIRS

A set of stone stairs leads down to a landing, then turns to the north. From beyond the bend, a faint rise of flickering light intermittently dances across the walls.

An entry chamber at the bottom of the stairs features a statue holding a broken seal next to an open stone door. It can be easily noticed that the door is spiked open.

Any character who reaches the base of the stairs and succeeds on a DC 11 Wisdom (Perception) check can hear distant voices.

Voices from ahead are raised as if in argument, but are too far away for any details of the conversation to be heard.

See the next area for more information.

AREA 12: WARDED CHAMBER

From the entry room of area 11, the characters will be able to see some of the details of this room through the open door, as you determine.

The floor of this rectangular chamber is breached directly in front of the door by a collapsed trap—a spiked pit fifteen feet across and nearly twenty-five feet side to side. Narrow ledges to both sides look as though they should allow passage around the pit. Near the center of the twenty-foot-high chamber, a *brazier of balance* stands unlit. A sealed sarcophagus is set off to the side.

It takes a successful DC 10 Dexterity check to walk around the spiked pit. On a failed check, a character falls into the pit and must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw. With a successful save, the character manages to land between the spikes, taking only 3 (1d6) slashing damage from their edges. On a failed save, the character slams down onto the spikes and takes 10 (3d6) piercing damage. If any character falls into the pit, the Grave Robbers across the room (see below) hear it and come over to investigate. Adjust the following part of the encounter as necessary.

THE GRAVE ROBBERS

When the characters have moved through the open door to see fully into the room, add the following details.

On the far side of the room, an oversized stone door stands closed. In shadowed light, two figures are pacing before the door and its lever, including one carrying an enormous sword. Their hushed argument carries across the room.

It takes a successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check to hear the details of the argument between the adventurers known as the Grave Robbers. If none of the characters can hear the conversation, paraphrase the following action.



The figure with the sword seems impatient as he grunts, “You going to be there all day? Or should I smash it open now?”

A figure closer to the door snarls back, “I’m a mage, not a rogue. There are heavy wards and strong magic keeping this door sealed.”

“So you try, then,” the warrior says to someone unseen.

“I told you, it’s a magic seal,” a third voice says. “Not my thing . . . Wait . . . what’s that?”

Suddenly, the third figure steps out from behind a pillar—an archer with bow drawn. “We have company,” she calls to her companions.

Whether spotting the characters’ light or hearing the sound of their movement, the Grave Robbers’ rogue becomes aware of the characters’ presence as they draw close.

FRIEND OR FOE?

This encounter can go a number of different ways, depending on whether the characters try to ally with the Grave Robbers, attempt to see them punished for their desecration of the crypts, or treat them as a direct threat and try to kill them outright.

If the characters try to broker a deal with the group, use roleplaying and DC 14 Charisma (Persuasion) checks to determine their success. The Grave Robbers are opportunistic but honest, and are happy to work with the characters to get through to the next chamber in exchange for a fair split of any treasure found there.

If the characters decide to fight the Grave Robbers—or if they fail badly at persuasion or try to intimidate the NPCs—the three are a potent threat.

If the characters want the Grave Robbers punished, the NPCs can be rendered unconscious if defeated, then tied up for delivery to Soulhearth when the adventure is done.

WARDED DOOR

Pulling on the lever of the stone door in this chamber has no effect as long as the powerful magical wards are in place that hold the door shut. A *detect magic* spell or similar effect, or a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check, reveals that two separate magical wards seal the door. The door can be forced open with a successful DC 30 Strength check, or its wards can be undone with two *knock* spells.

A character who studies the door and succeeds on a DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check senses that its magic feeds into the room in some way—a clue that lighting the brazier also unseals the door’s magical locks. When the brazier is lit, a pulse of light at the door announces that the wards have been disabled. Pulling the lever then opens the door.

TREASURE

If the characters fight and defeat the Grave Robbers, they can claim their gear and treasure—mundane

THE GRAVE ROBBERS

If the characters decide to take on the Grave Robbers, they are in for a tough fight:

- **Samulkin Farcaster** is a tiefling mage and the leader of the group, who uses bravado to hide when he feels that he’s in a bit over his head. Use **illusionist** stats for Samulkin.
- **Gromlik Three-Teeth** is a heavily armored warrior with sword and shield. Most folk think he’s a dwarf, but no one really wants to ask. Use **knight** statistics for Gromlik.
- **Cailyassa Forgedawn** is a half-elf rogue with a shortbow—and a short temper. Use **scout** statistics for Cailyassa.

Their experience and savvy make the Grave Robbers a challenge for even a 5th-level party. For lower-level characters, make the following adjustments to Samulkin’s and Gromlik’s stats:

- For a **3rd-level party**, Samulkin has already expended his 3rd- and 4th-level spell slots and has only 19 hit points. Gromlik has only 26 hit points and cannot use his Leadership ability.
- For a **4th-level party**, Samulkin has already expended his 4th-level spell slot and has only 28 hit points. Gromlik has only 35 hit points.

weapons and armor, three *potions of healing*, coins and gems worth 45 gp, and one uncommon consumable magic item of your choice.

AREA 13: FINAL CRYPT

A low-ceilinged chamber holds a statue of Kelemvor in the northeast corner, with a large chest before it and a broken seal at its feet. A single ornate sarcophagus stands to the west, with a dusty open book set on one of four small plinths that surround it. A dead body sprawls before the sarcophagus, whose sides are marked with skulls and whose engraving carries an arcane flavor not seen in the previous crypts.

With a successful DC 13 Intelligence (Arcana or History) check, a character recognizes that the sarcophagus’s inscriptions are Thayan in nature. A character with a background related to Thay knows this automatically.

The book on the plinth is a dusty prayer book left here by the Kelemvorites, and worth 10 gp to a temple. The body is an acolyte who died in this place during an earlier rising of undead.

VENGEFUL UNDEAD

A long-dead mage in the sarcophagus has been raised as a **flameskull** and woken from its undead slumber by the opening of the door into this area. Seeking freedom, it starts to hammer against the lid of its coffin. If the characters lift the sarcophagus lid, the flameskull attacks at once. If they do not, it casts *lightning bolt* (which it has prepared instead of *fireball*) to blast the sarcophagus open before it attacks. Any characters within 10 feet of the sarcophagus must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or be struck by shattered



stone for 10 (3d6) damage. Other characters might “accidentally” be caught in the line of the blind-fired *lightning bolt*, as you see fit.

If the Grave Robbers have accompanied the characters into this area, have them join the fight by giving their statistics blocks to three of the players. In that event, the flameskull has 80 hit points and can use its Fire Ray four times with its Multiattack trait. Roll randomly for each attack to determine whether the flameskull targets the player characters or the NPCs.

If the characters can lure the flameskull into the light of the burning brazier in area 12, it will take damage only once from the brazier’s light before retreating and attacking at range.

BACK DOOR

The characters (and any surviving Grave Robbers) can use the door in area 13 to leave the crypt if they have no reason to retrace their route back through the dungeon. However, the door has no lever, meaning it must be opened manually or with magic.

The stairs climb sixty feet before emerging through a concealed door in a mausoleum near the temple of Kelemvor. (Soulhearth and his fellow acolytes were unaware of this long-forgotten second entrance into the crypts, and are grateful to the characters for bringing it to their attention so they can close it off.)

TREASURE

The sarcophagus contains only rotting robes. The chest contains tokens and offerings to Kelemvor, most of which are worthless—but includes gems and coins worth a total of 200 gp.

If the Grave Robbers fought through to this area with the characters, increase the amount of treasure so that the characters’ equal share amounts to the total above, and add an uncommon consumable magic item of your choice. The Grave Robbers are more interested in the cash, allowing the characters to haggle for the magic as you see fit.

EPILOGUE

If the characters fought alongside the Grave Robbers, the NPCs try to beat feet once above ground, not wanting to explain their presence in the crypts to the Kelemvorites. If the characters captured the NPCs, they can deliver them to Soulhearth along with the broken seals. He gives the characters the promised 20 gp, along with his thanks.

Doomguide Soulhearth greets you happily upon your return. “By the scales, you are back! And with the broken seals! Very well done.” He beckons two younger priests to take the seals, then shakes each of you by the hand. “Thank you, friends. Your efforts have saved many today. We will repair and replace the seals before any more of those foul undead escape to ravage our countryside.”

“We are but humble priests here. But please, take this token of our appreciation. Safe travels, and may Kelemvor always keep your path in the balance.”

Editing, development, and layout for *Dragon+*:
Scott Fitzgerald Gray